# SQUEEZE PLAYS

## ABOUT THE DEALS

Feel free to disagree with the bidding; it is only there so as to get to a contract appropriate for some particular squeeze play. In fact, the bidding is irrelevant except in Deals where the opponent's bids may influence your actions.

With both hands visible and the opening lead noted you are asked to make a Plan for each Deal. This is to get you started thinking about how you would play the hand.

Having the defender's hands visible at the second page is not a perfect scenario. For example, there will be situations where you, as Declarer, are still playing for a suit to split 3-3 when you only have to peek at the hands to see that the split is 4-2. However, the other possibility of keeping the defender's hands hidden until later would prevent you from seeing how your plays are squeezing them. On balance, we decided to use the more open method.

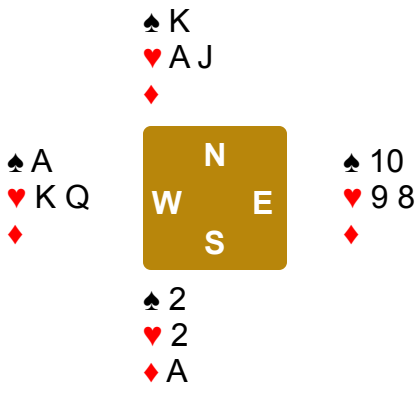
You are always going to be the Declarer, playing in the South position.

You will notice that a large portion of the 20 Deals are slam hands. This is not because Squeezes don't arise in lower contracts, just that the presentation and explanations are less cluttered when there is only one (or none) trick that can be lost.

## SQUEEZE PLAYS SUMMARY

The basic principle of a Squeeze Play can be summed up with this statement.

> A DEFENDER CANNOT HOLD ON TO THREE GUARD CARDS WHEN HE HAS ONLY TWO CARDS IN HIS HAND




South is in her hand and she plays the ♦A.

West cannot throw his ♠A because dummy's ♠K would then be high.

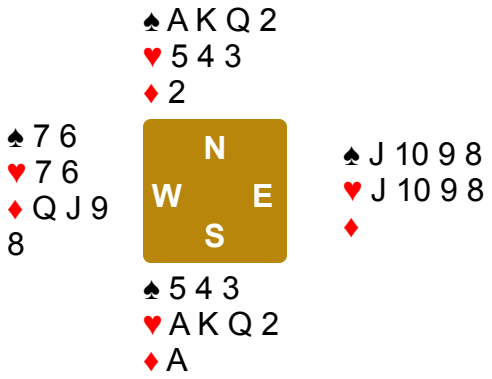
But he also cannot throw his ♥Q because then South would discard dummy's ♠K and win two tricks with ♥A, ♥J.

We say that West is Squeezed in ♠s and ♥s. He needed to keep all three cards at a time when he had to come down to just two.

The statement in the blue box is definitely True, but it isn't complete.
You could also say:
A defender cannot hold four guards when he has only three cards.

Or even:
A defender cannot hold eight guards when he has only seven cards.

You get the idea. Look at an example of the eight and seven situation:



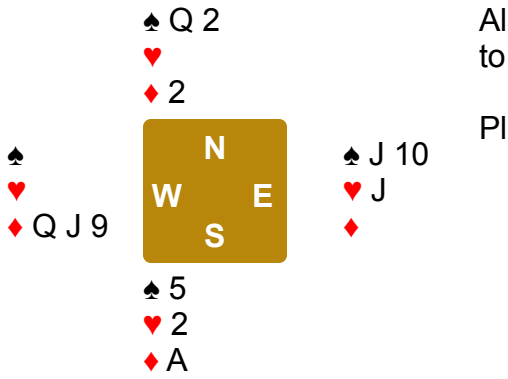

South is in her hand and she plays the ♦A.

East needs to keep all 4 ♠s to stop dummy's ♠2.

But he also must keep all 4 ♥s to stop your ♥2, (though he might not realize the importance of this).

We say that East is Squeezed in ♠s and ♥s. He needed to keep all eight cards at a time when he had to come down to just seven.

Perhaps it is already obvious to you that all those extra winners in each hand don't affect the fundamental squeeze position. Take the last example and play dummy's ♠ A K and then your own ♥ A K Q. You would then have this basic position:




All the extra winners have already been won and you are down to basics.

Play the ♦A and squeeze East in ♠s and ♥s.

There are three terms we use when talking about squeezes.

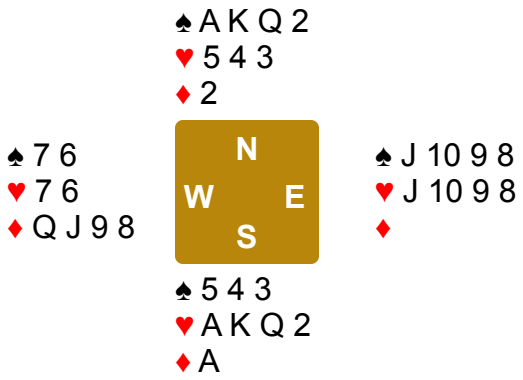
A **THREAT** is a card which is not yet a winner but THREATENS to become a winner if a defender discards a higher card in the suit. In the example above your ♥2 and dummy's ♠2 are both Threats.

A **GUARD** is a card(s) held by a defender that is preventing one of your Threats from becoming a winner. East's ♠ J 10 is a Guard against dummy's ♠2 and East's ♥J is a Guard against your ♥2.

The **SQUEEZE CARD** is the card you play which forces a defender to give up one of his Guards. Here the Squeeze Card was the ♦A.

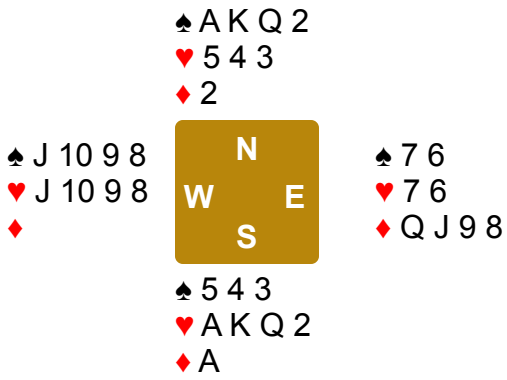
**Automatic Squeeze:**

Remember this?




South plays the ♦A and **EAST** is Squeezed in ♠s and ♥s.

Suppose the East and West hands were switched:



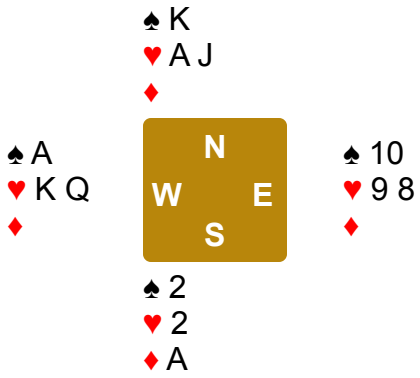

South plays the ♦A and **WEST** is Squeezed in ♠s and ♥s.

An automatic squeeze is just a squeeze which will work equally well against either defender.

Deal 1 shows you a full example of an automatic squeeze. Feel free to go there right now and then come back for the next bit.

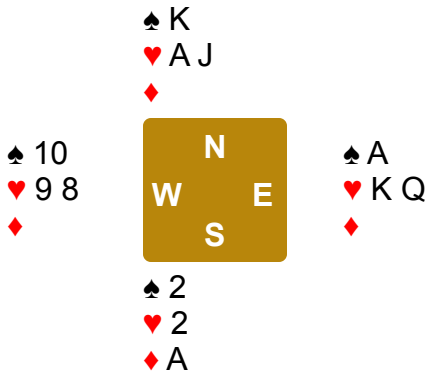
**Positional Squeeze:**

Remember this?




South plays the ♦A and **WEST** is Squeezed in ♠s and ♥s.

Suppose the East and West hands were switched:




South plays the ♦A and **EAST** is not squeezed at all!
In fact it is dummy that is squeezed. Since dummy has to play before East does, East just watches and discards the same suit as dummy.

This is a Positional Squeeze, so called because it only works on one of the Defenders.

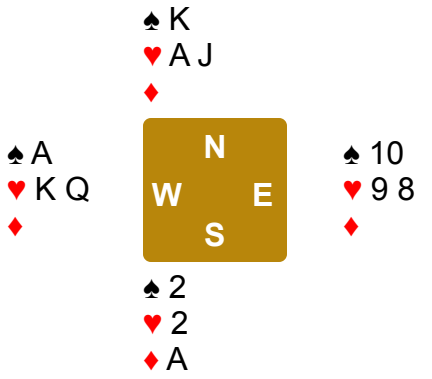
Deal 2 is an example of a positional squeeze. Feel free to go check it out, then come back.

**Rectifying the Count:**

That may sound rather high-tech but it's not really that bad.

MOST SQUEEZES CAN ONLY OCCUR WHEN
YOU MUST WIN ALL THE REST OF THE TRICKS

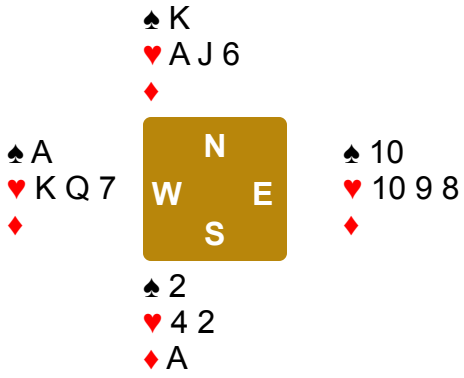
Look at this end position one more time.




South needs to win all the rest of the tricks.

South plays the ♦A and WEST is squeezed in ♠s and ♥s.
He is squeezed because all of his cards are Busy - they are all doing guardwork.

Now give everybody an extra ♥.




South needs to win 3 of the last 4 tricks.

South plays the ♦A and WEST is not squeezed.
He has one card, the ♥7, which is not Busy doing guardwork.
So he just discards that card and awaits his two tricks.

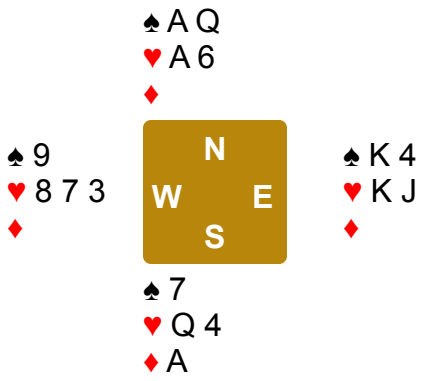
If you checked out Deals 1 and 2 earlier you didn't run across this problem. And for a very good reason - both of those Deals involved Grand Slams so you were already in a spot where you needed the "rest of the tricks".

When you are playing a small slam, though, rectifying the count is vital. So when your Plan calls for a squeeze to be made at the end you will have to give up one trick to the defenders early.

Deal 3 (surprise) just happens to demonstrate rectifying the count. So if you want to see it work in the context of a full deal just check that out and then come back when you are done.

**The Vienna Coup:**

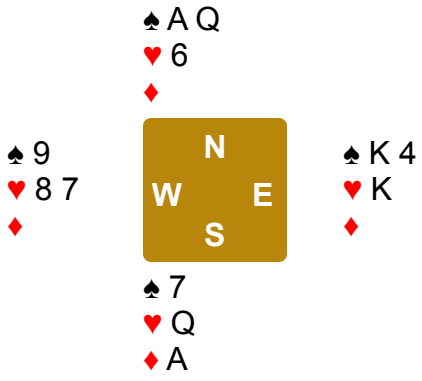
Nice name, huh?
Take a look at this ending, where South needs to win all four tricks. South is in her hand and can certainly win the three Aces. She has two Threats, the ♠Q and the ♥Q with which she hope to squeeze East.




South plays the ♦A and discards the ♥6 from dummy.

East will throw his ♥J because he can see that he must hold onto both ♠s.
Dummy's ♥A now drops the ♥K, and establishes South's ♥Q.
**BUT SHE HAS NO ENTRY TO IT, SHE IS LOCKED IN DUMMY**.

So, let us apply the Vienna Coup! At some earlier time, perhaps the first trick, or the fourth trick or whenever, dummy's ♥A was played. So the ending would now look like this:




South plays the ♦A and discards the ♥6 from dummy.

East is squeezed in ♥s and ♠s.
The difference here is that South no longer needs an extra entry to her ♥Q because she is already in her hand.

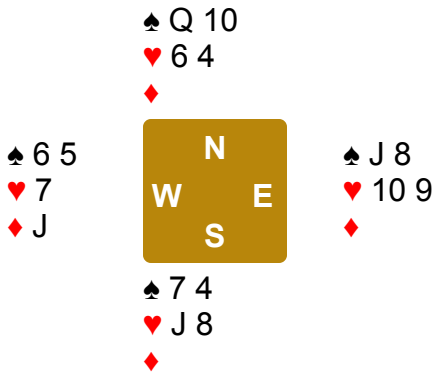
THE VIENNA COUP IS THE CASHING OF A HIGH CARD IN ONE HAND TO CREATE A THREAT IN THE OTHER HAND

Want to see the Vienna Coup in action?
Go to Deal 7, then come on back.

**The Suicide Squeeze: (aka the Cannibal Squeeze)**

This squeeze often occurs when the defenders have made a mistake, but there are some situations where they defend perfectly and still get caught in it. What happens is that one defender cashes a winner and in so doing squeezes his partner.

Look at this ending:




West cashes the ♦J.

Discard the ♥4 from dummy and the ♠4 from your hand. East is squeezed and you win the last three tricks.

If West had just ignored the ♦ winner and led one of the other suits East would have been assured of taking 2 tricks.

There is just one Suicide Squeeze Deal presented in this set so I won't identify it for you, just be on the lookout.

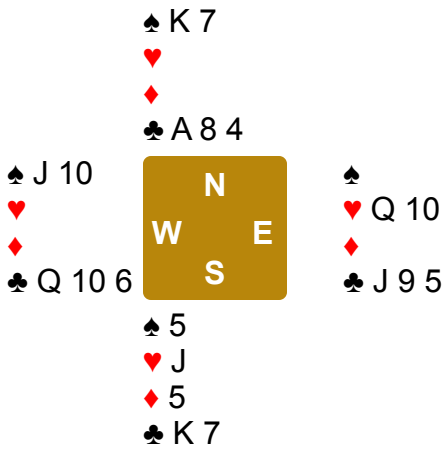
**The Double Squeeze:**

Usually you think of a squeeze occuring when one defender is trying to guard two suits. In these descriptions we have often said "East is squeezed in ♠s and ♥s." But sometimes when you are trying to set up a squeeze on one player it will turn out that West guards one suit but East guards the other suit. So you try to get a situation where neither one can guard a THIRD suit.

That sounds messier than it should. Suppose you have a long ♦ suit which you play to use for a squeeze. It turns out that West guards a ♠ threat while East guards a ♥ threat.

You will say to yourself: "West guards the spades, East guards the hearts, nobody can guard the clubs."

Here is how it works:




You play your ♦5.

West is not squeezed, but he must keep both ♠s to guard against dummy so he is forced to discard a ♣. Since you know your ♠7 cannot win a trick now you throw it. East is not squeezed, he can spare the ♥10.

But you then play a ♠ to dummy's ♠K. This squeezes East who now has the sole guard for both ♥s and ♣s. He will probably throw his ♣5 in which case you take the last 3 ♣ tricks.

Deal 13 is a good example of a Double Squeeze.

**That's all folks:**

I didn't start this lesson by talking about how difficult Squeeze Plays are. As you have seen, though, they do require some effort, both learning how to execute them and in the execution itself. Most of the examples here are classified as Simple Squeezes. There is another whole level.

If your interest is piqued you might want to look for the Vise Squeeze, or perhaps the Winkle and the Stepping-Stone squeeze. How about the Trump Squeeze or the Criss-cross squeeze?

Good luck.

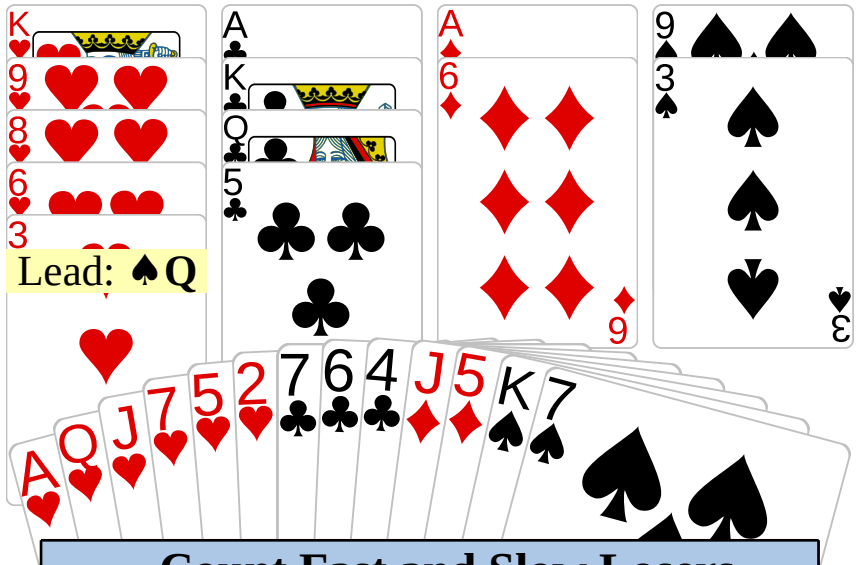
**Deal 1** Ctr: **6NT** Goal: at least ____ winners




| Count Sure Winners | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| ♠ | ♥ | ♦ | ♣ | Total |
| | | | | |

| Decide How to Develop Winners | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| Promotion | Length | Finesse | End Play |
| | | | |

**Deal 2** Ctr: **6♥** Goal: at most ____ losers




| Count Fast and Slow Losers | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| ♠ | ♥ | ♦ | ♣ | Total |
| | | | | |

| Decide How to Reduce Losers | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| Ruffs | Finesse | Pitch | Length |
| | | | |

**Deal 3** Ctr: **7NT** Goal: at least ____ winners



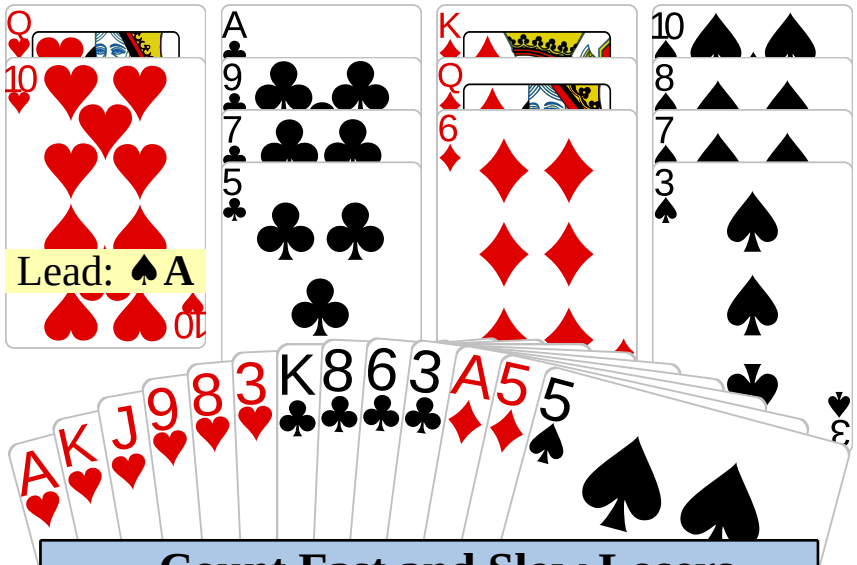

| Count Sure Winners | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| ♠ | ♥ | ♦ | ♣ | Total |
| | | | | |
| **Decide How to Develop Winners** | | | | |
| Promotion | Length | Finesse | End Play | |
| | | | | |

**Deal 4** Ctr: **7NT** Goal: at least ____ winners




| Count Sure Winners | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| ♠ | ♥ | ♦ | ♣ | Total |
| | | | | |
| **Decide How to Develop Winners** | | | | |
| Promotion | Length | Finesse | End Play | |
| | | | | |

**Deal 5** Ctr: **6♥** Goal: at most ____ losers




| Count Fast and Slow Losers | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| ♠ | ♥ | ♦ | ♣ | Total |
| | | | | |

| Decide How to Reduce Losers | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| Ruffs | Finesse | Pitch | Length |
| | | | |

Board: 1
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 6NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♥J

Board: 2
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 6♥
Declarer: East
Lead: ♠Q

Board: 3
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 7NT
Declarer: South
Lead: ♥K

Board: 4
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 7NT
Declarer: West
Lead: ♠Q

Board: 5
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 6♥
Declarer: North
Lead: ♠A

***Board 1***
South Deals
None Vul

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | ♠ 9 3<br>♥ K Q<br>♦ A K Q J 9 3<br>♣ Q 8 3 | |
| ♠ J 10 8 6<br>♥ A 8 4 2<br>♦ 5<br>♣ K 9 4 2 | N<br>W E<br>S | ♠ 7 4 2<br>♥ J 10 9 6 3<br>♦ 8 6 4<br>♣ J 6 |
| | ♠ A K Q 5<br>♥ 7 5<br>♦ 10 7 2<br>♣ A 10 7 5 | |

| *West* | *North* | *East* | *South* |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | | 1♣ |
| Pass | 2♦ | Pass | 2♠ |
| Pass | 4NT[1] | Pass | 5♥[2] |
| Pass | 6NT | | |
| All Pass | | | |

1. Blackwood
2. 2 aces

6NT by North
Lead: ♥J

North is to play 6NT. East leads the ♥J. West wins the ♥A and returns the ♥2.

With only 11 winners you need to find one more and your prospects are quite slim.

No matter how the ♠s split only one defender will hold the Guard because only one defender can have as many as 4. IF (it's a big IF) that same defender holds the ♣K then you can squeeze him.

Can you see how the squeeze is going to work?

If you try to run your ♦s right away you will have a problem with your ♣Q later on. It will be no good as a Threat card because you will have no entry back to your hand.

East plays low.

The solution is the Vienna Coup: a ♣ to the ♣A at trick 3.

Then start running the ♦ suit.

This is the situation after you have unblocked dummy's ♣A and then played 5 ♦ winners.

So far neither defender is hurting, but that is about to change.

East discards.

You play your ♦3 and discard dummy's ♣10.

West is squeezed. He can't throw his ♣K without letting your ♣Q become a winner. But if he discards a ♠ dummy's ♠5 will win the last trick. This is soooo much fun.

***Board 2***
East Deals
N-S Vul

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | ♠ A 8 5 2<br>♥ 4<br>♦ K Q 8 3<br>♣ J 10 9 3 | |
| ♠ 9 3<br>♥ K 9 8 6 3<br>♦ A 6<br>♣ A K Q 5 |  | ♠ K 7<br>♥ A Q J 7 5 2<br>♦ J 5<br>♣ 7 6 4 |
| | ♠ Q J 10 6 4<br>♥ 10<br>♦ 10 9 7 4 2<br>♣ 8 2 | |

| *West* | *North* | *East* | *South* |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | 1♥ | Pass |
| 3♣ | Pass | 3♥ | Pass |
| 6♥ | | | |
| All Pass | | | |

6♥ by East
Lead: ♠Q

Play 5 ♥ winners and the ♠K.

Drum roll please.

South discards.

Play your ♥2 and dump dummy's ♦6.

North has no answer.

East is to play 6♥. South leads the ♠Q. North wins the ♠A and plays the ♦K.

Of course you have noticed that in most of these hands you are exactly one trick short. No coincidence - it's when you are one trick short and can't find another likely plan that you start to look for a squeeze.

In this hand dummy's fourth ♣ is an obvious Threat, so you should ask yourself if you can find another Threat for when ♣s don't split 3-3. Another thing you have probably noticed is that although 3-3 splits happen about 40% of the time in real life, they **NEVER** happen in these pages!

North's ♦K play helps you find the other Threat. It appears that he must hold the ♦Q also, so your ♦J is now a Threat against North. If he holds 4 ♣s you can squeeze him.

***Board 3***
East Deals
None Vul

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | ♠ A 5 2<br>♥ J 6<br>♦ A K J 7 5 3<br>♣ K 7 | |
| ♠ 8<br>♥ K Q 10 7 5<br>♦ 10 8 4<br>♣ J 9 5 2 | N<br>W E<br>S | ♠ J 10 9 6 4<br>♥ 9 8 3 2<br>♦ —<br>♣ Q 10 6 3 |
| | ♠ K Q 7 3<br>♥ A 4<br>♦ Q 9 6 2<br>♣ A 8 4 | |

| *West* | *North* | *East* | *South* |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | Pass | 1NT |
| Pass | 3♦ | Pass | 4♦ |
| Pass | 4NT[1] | Pass | 5♥[2] |
| Pass | 7NT | | |
| All Pass | | | |

1. Blackwood
2. 2 aces

7NT by South
Lead: ♥K

South is to play 7NT. West leads the ♥K, dummy plays the ♥6 and East the ♥2.

With 12 obvious tricks your first thought should be that perhaps the ♠s will split 3-3.

Then, your second thought should be that dummy's ♥J is a Threat against West's ♥Q, so if it is West who holds 4 ♠s you will be able to squeeze him.

Since the contract is 7NT you take the first trick with the ♥A.

With one trick in the bag you should test ♦s next. When you play the ♦A East discards a ♠.

You continue with the ♦Q and ♦ K, East discarding a ♥ and a ♣.

Since East has shown up with a ♦ void he has become the odds-on favorite to hold the ♠ Guard. His ♠ discard makes it very likely that he started with 5 ♠s.

To find out for sure you play ♠A, then ♠Q. Sure enough West discards a ♥ on the second round.

You can't squeeze West in ♥s and ♠s because he doesn't hold the ♠ Guard, East does.

But now a completely new possibility shows up. Say to yourself, over and over, "West must guard ♥s, and East must guard ♠s. Nobody can guard ♣s."

You start playing dummy's ♦ winners.

With one more ♦ in dummy, things look like this.

East discards the ♣6.

When you play the ♦5 East must keep both ♠s to guard against your ♠7. So he discards the ♣6, hoping partner can stop that suit.

Your ♠7 is now worthless so you throw it.

West has no problem, (yet), he discards the ♥10.

It is now time to pressure West.

Play dummy's ♠5 to your ♠K.

West MUST keep his ♥Q so he releases his ♣5.

And you win the last three tricks with ♣K, ♣A, ♣8.

***Board 4***
West Deals
Both Vul

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | ♠ Q J 10 8 3<br>♥ J 10 7 2<br>♦ 6 3<br>♣ 10 6 | |
| ♠ A K 7 4<br>♥ A K 5<br>♦ K Q 10<br>♣ A K 2 | N<br>W E<br>S | ♠ 9 5 2<br>♥ 6<br>♦ A J 9 7 4<br>♣ Q 8 4 3 |
| | ♠ 6<br>♥ Q 9 8 4 3<br>♦ 8 5 2<br>♣ J 9 7 5 | |

| *West* | *North* | *East* | *South* |
|---|---|---|---|
| 2♣ | Pass | 3♦ | Pass |
| 4NT[1] | Pass | 5♦[2] | Pass |
| 7NT | | | |
| All Pass | | | |

1. Blackwood
2. 1 ace

7NT by West
Lead: ♠Q

West is to play 7NT. North leads the ♠Q.

One more winner is needed. Dummy's fourth ♣ is a possibility.

So take the ♠K and play ♣ A K Q.

North discards a ♠ on the third ♣.

Now you know South guards the ♣s.

Before tackling ♦s, see what you can discover about ♠s.

Play the ♠A. South discards a ♥.

South guards the ♣s. North guards the ♠s. Nobody can guard the ♥s.

Play 4 rounds of ♦s.

On the fourth ♦ South had to discard a ♥. You discarded a small ♠. North discarded a ♠ on the third ♦ and a ♥ on the fourth.

South discards a ♥.

You play dummy's ♦4. South cannot throw the ♣J or he will set up dummy's ♣8, so he discards a ♥.

You discard the ♠7.

Now North is squeezed. He cannot discard the ♠J or he will set up dummy's ♠9, so he discards a ♥.

You win the last three ♥ tricks with another Double Squeeze.

***Board 5***
North Deals
N-S Vul

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | ♠ 5<br>♥ A K J 9 8 3<br>♦ A 5<br>♣ K 8 6 3 | |
| ♠ Q 6 2<br>♥ 7 5 2<br>♦ J 9 8 4 3<br>♣ J 4 | N<br>W E<br>S | ♠ A K J 9 4<br>♥ 6 4<br>♦ 10 7 2<br>♣ Q 10 2 |
| | ♠ 10 8 7 3<br>♥ Q 10<br>♦ K Q 6<br>♣ A 9 7 5 | |

| *West* | *North* | *East* | *South* |
|---|---|---|---|
| | 1♥ | 1♠ | 2♣ |
| Pass | 3♥ | Pass | 4♥ |
| Pass | 4NT[1] | Pass | 5♦[2] |
| Pass | 6♥ | | |
| All Pass | | | |

1. Blackwood
2. 1 ace

6♥ by North
Lead: ♠A

from your hand.

Then lead dummy's ♣7 to your ♣K.

Here you are in your hand.

Only East can guard dummy's ♠10, and only East can guard dummy's♣9.

East discards the ♣10, holding on to the ♠J.

You play your ♥A and East must give up one of his guards. If he holds on to the ♠J then you toss dummy's useless ♠10. If he throws the ♠J then you toss dummy's ♣9.

North is to play 6♥. East leads the ♠A, then ♠K.

When you looked at just your and dummy's cards on the previous page it may have looked impossible to find a twelfth winner.

Even looking at all four hands here it is still very difficult to come up with a plan.

Here's a hint: If East holds 3 ♣s, (and you see that he does), can you squeeze him in ♣s and ♠s?

Of course you ruffed the ♠K.

The big problem with trying to squeeze East in the black suits right now is that West actually holds a ♠ guard. But you can fix that.

You draw two rounds of trumps with dummy's ♥Q and ♥10.

West plays the ♠Q and you ruff. Then you pull the last trump.

Now play the ♦A, ♦K, and ♦Q, discarding the ♣3